

How to Build a Skill

A general framework for turning any task you do often into a reusable skill. Works for reports, replies, research, triage, formatting, onboarding, anything with a repeatable shape.

WHAT A SKILL IS

One Markdown file, **SKILL.md**, plus an optional **assets/** folder. You are teaching a procedure, once, so it runs the same way every time.

A THE BUILD, IN SIX MOVES

1 CHOOSE the task

Pick something you repeat, where the steps stay the same even as the content changes.

Not a one-off. A task with a **stable shape**: same moves each time, different inputs.

2 SCOPE it and name it

Write what it does, and the phrases you would say to ask for it, plus a hard boundary.

Triggers say **when to fire**; a "not for X" line says when **not** to. One input, one job.

3 CAPTURE the rules in your head

The "always" and "never" you apply without thinking, and what to do when info is missing.

Guardrails first, before the steps, so they govern everything. **Missing fact = flag it, never guess.**

4 WRITE the procedure

Order the steps like a brief to a sharp new hire: take in, do the work, format, check, hand off.

Give every judgment call a **written rule**, so the same input always gives the same output.

5 BUNDLE the fixed pieces

Drop the fixed pieces into assets/: templates, reference tables, brand files, checklists.

The skill **copies and fills** these instead of inventing structure from memory.

6 TEST on real cases

Run it on your messiest real examples and watch where it guesses.

Every guess it makes becomes your **next rule**. That loop is how a skill gets trustworthy.

B IS IT A SKILL? (THE TEST)

- ? You do it **repeatedly**, on a schedule or on demand.
- ? Same **shape** every time; only the content changes.
- ? You often start from a **past example** and edit.
- ? The output has a **consistent format**.
- ? The judgment is **rule-based**, not fresh invention.

Three or more yes → make it a skill.

C FOUR LAWS THAT MAKE IT HOLD

- 1 **Fill structure, don't invent it**
Ship the fixed pieces as a file the skill copies.
- 2 **Flag the unknown, never fake it**
A gap becomes a labeled to-do, not a hidden risk.
- 3 **Same result every time**
Run it twice, get the same result. Every choice follows a written rule.
- 4 **Verify before delivering**
The skill checks its own work before it says done.

D WHAT YOU ARE ACTUALLY WRITING: ONE SKILL.MD FILE

name + description

The trigger. Read to decide when to use the skill. List the say-it-out-loud phrases, plus a hard "not for" boundary.

the body

The procedure. Guardrails first, then numbered steps (take in, do, format), then a self-check, then an exact delivery spec.

assets/

The fixed pieces. Optional folder of templates and references the skill copies, so it fills structure rather than guessing it.